

ARGUMENTATIVE ESSAY — ACADEMIC ENGLISH II

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The Exam Passed, the Mind Unchanged

Why Bangladesh's university system produces graduates who can pass exams but cannot write or think critically

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Portfolio note

This is an argumentative essay written for Academic English II, which teaches the structure and conventions of academic argumentation: thesis statement, evidence-based body paragraphs, counterargument, rebuttal, and proper citation. The topic — the gap between examination performance and critical thinking in Bangladeshi higher education — is one I chose because I had begun to see the problem from the inside, both as a student transferring from the University of Dhaka's exam-centred system and as someone entering journalism, where the ability to think through an argument matters more than the ability to reproduce one. Two years after writing this essay, I now teach Academic English at ULAB's Centre for Language Studies, where the deficit this essay describes is the first thing I encounter every semester.

Bangladesh's higher education system graduates hundreds of thousands of students every year. Most of them have passed their examinations. Many have passed with high marks. The question this essay raises is whether passing an examination and developing the capacity to think critically are the same achievement, and the answer it argues is that, in the Bangladeshi context, they are frequently not. The system is designed around a model of assessment that rewards the reproduction of memorised content and penalises the kind of independent reasoning, evidence evaluation, and written argumentation that employers, graduate programmes, and democratic life require. The result is a population of graduates who hold credentials but lack the intellectual competence those credentials are supposed to certify.

This is not an argument against examinations as such. Examinations serve real purposes: they standardise assessment, they provide accountability, and they motivate study. The argument is that when examinations become the sole or dominant mode of assessment, and when the examinations themselves test recall rather than reasoning, the system produces a specific and harmful distortion. Students learn to pass rather than to think, and the passing becomes, over time, a substitute for the thinking rather than evidence of it. This essay examines three dimensions of that distortion — the structure of assessment, the culture of pedagogy, and the downstream consequences for graduates — before addressing the strongest counterargument and proposing that the deficit is systemic rather than individual.

The first dimension of this distortion is the assessment structure itself. The dominant mode of assessment in Bangladeshi universities, particularly in the public sector and the national university system, is the written examination requiring students to answer questions from a known syllabus within a fixed time. The format varies — broad questions, short answers, multiple choice — but the underlying logic is consistent: the student is expected to reproduce content covered in lectures and textbooks. The examination tests whether the student has retained the material, not whether the student can do anything with it. Analysis, evaluation, synthesis, and the construction of original argument are not systematically assessed because the format does not require them.

The consequences of this assessment model are already visible at the level of student writing. Rahman, Hossain, and Uddin (2024), in a qualitative case study at a Bangladeshi government college, find weak academic writing among the students they observed — limited vocabulary, poor organisation, thin critical reasoning — and attribute these patterns not to individual failure but to an examination-centred secondary school system that rarely teaches writing as a process. Their findings are drawn from a single institution and are not nationally representative, but they are consistent with what any instructor in the Bangladeshi tertiary system recognises: students arrive at university having been trained to memorise and reproduce, and the university's own assessment often continues to reward exactly the same behaviour.

The structural incentive is clear. If the examination asks a student to “Discuss the features of romanticism,” the rational response is to memorise a list of features and write them out. The examination does not ask the student to argue whether romanticism's emphasis on individual feeling was a liberation or an evasion, to evaluate competing scholarly accounts of the movement, or to apply the concept to a contemporary case. Those are the tasks that develop critical thinking. They are also the tasks that are hardest to grade at scale, which is part of why the system avoids them.

The second dimension follows directly from the first: assessment drives pedagogy, not the reverse. When the examination tests recall, the classroom becomes a site of transmission: the instructor delivers content, the students record it, and both

parties understand that the purpose of the interaction is to transfer material from one location (the lecture, the textbook) to another (the student's examination script). This model leaves little room for the activities through which critical thinking is actually developed: open-ended discussion, the writing and revision of arguments, the evaluation of evidence, the experience of having one's reasoning challenged by a peer or an instructor and having to defend or revise it.

The problem is self-reinforcing. Instructors who attempt discussion-based or writing-intensive pedagogy face practical resistance: larger class sizes, institutional pressure to cover a fixed syllabus, and students who have been trained since school to expect transmission and who experience open-ended questioning as a sign that the instructor is not doing their job. Freire (1970) described this as the "banking concept" of education, in which students are treated as containers to be filled with deposits of information rather than as agents capable of constructing knowledge through dialogue. The banking metaphor remains uncomfortably accurate for much of Bangladeshi higher education, not because instructors are unaware of better approaches but because the assessment system and the institutional culture make the banking model the path of least resistance.

The third dimension is the downstream cost, which extends well beyond the university. Employers in Bangladesh routinely report that graduates lack the communication, reasoning, and problem-solving skills that professional work requires, even when those graduates hold first-class degrees. The World Bank's assessment of Bangladesh's skills landscape has repeatedly noted a mismatch between the qualifications the education system produces and the competencies the labour market demands. The gap is not primarily about technical knowledge; it is about the higher-order capacities — critical analysis, written argumentation, the evaluation of conflicting evidence — that an exam-centred system structurally neglects.

The cost is also civic. Democratic citizenship requires the ability to evaluate claims, to distinguish evidence from assertion, to recognise when an argument is being made badly or dishonestly. These are not natural endowments; they are skills that education is supposed to cultivate. A system that graduates students who can recall the

definition of democracy but cannot evaluate a newspaper editorial's reasoning has fulfilled its credentialing function while failing its educational one. The distinction matters, because the credential is what the student carries into the job market and the voting booth, and when the credential is not backed by the competence it implies, both the student and the society that trusted the credential are worse off.

Against this critique, however, the strongest defence of examination-based assessment deserves a serious hearing. Examinations are standardised, scalable, and comparatively resistant to corruption — all of which matter in a context where the alternatives are vulnerable to favouritism, inconsistent grading, and institutional capture. In a system where subjective assessment might be influenced by a student's family connections, political affiliations, or willingness to pay, the examination offers a brutally objective measure: you either wrote the correct answer or you did not. This is a real virtue, and any reform proposal that ignores it is naive about the institutional realities of Bangladeshi higher education.

The rebuttal is not that this defence is wrong but that it is incomplete. Fairness in assessment is important, but fairness is not the only criterion; validity matters too. A fair assessment that measures the wrong thing is still a failed assessment. An examination that reliably and impartially measures a student's ability to memorise a textbook is fair in its administration but invalid as a measure of the student's capacity to think, argue, or reason. The challenge for reform is therefore not to abandon examinations but to redesign them so that what they measure — and therefore what students are incentivised to learn — includes the higher-order skills the current format excludes. Process-based assessment components, in-class writing under controlled conditions, structured oral defences, and evaluated research exercises can all be made fair and transparent while testing capacities that recall-based examinations cannot reach.

Taken together, these three dimensions — the assessment structure, the pedagogy it produces, and the downstream consequences it generates — point to a single conclusion. Bangladesh's university system is not producing graduates who cannot think. It is producing graduates who have never been systematically required to. The

distinction matters, because it locates the problem in the structure rather than in the students, and structures can be changed. The examination system rewards memorisation because it was designed to, and students respond rationally to the incentives it sets. If the system assessed reasoning, argument, and evidence evaluation with the same seriousness it currently assesses recall, students would develop those capacities — not because they are more virtuous but because the incentive would point in a different direction. The exam would still be passed. But the mind that passed it would be changed.

References

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